



## Speed-Reading Academic Articles

Journal articles should be read differently than novels or popular press books. It takes practice and an essential set of skills to read an academic article efficiently and effectively. This module will help you to:

1. Screen articles quickly
  2. Boost your comprehension of articles that you read
  3. Write better from reading articles
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### 1. Screen the Article

1. Before delving in, you should do some investigating to determine if the article is even worth reading. Use the following metrics:
  - a. Is the journal that published the article credible?
  - b. Look at the citation list of the article to check if it is comprehensive and cites reputable sources.
  - c. Do a brief search on the authors to measure their credibility and better place their research intentions in the field. Also check out the references at the end of the article and the journal's reputation.
  - d. Read the abstract as a quick test of the article's relevance to your needs.

### 2. Active Reading

1. Read actively by asking yourself questions about the article as you read it. Writing Commons contributor Brogan Sullivan suggests thinking about reading as a conversation between you and the text. See the article [here](#).

2. Read an article multiple times, each time looking for different aspects of the article and bringing yourself to a new level of comprehension.
3. If you are crunched for time, just read once or twice.
4. If you're reading the article on your computer via a PDF or website, you can search the document for important words to locate them quickly.
5. Another way to screen an article is to read the abstract to see if it is worth your time to delve into the rest.
6. Highlight the most pertinent phrases. These could be topic sentences or sentences that directly refer to your interests.
7. Take notes in the margin, in a Word document, on a notebook, or using post-its while you read the article.
8. Write notes in your own words summarizing sections of the article.
9. Engage in a dialogue with the article by summarizing it out loud. Do this every time you feel saturated with or confused by the material.
10. The following table provides a toolbox to help you get the most out of your time with an article. You need not follow the outline exactly but experiment with different reading methods to find which works best for you.

**Table 1: Stages of active reading**

| Stage       | What to Read                                                                                          | What You Should Understand                                                                                | Tasks                                                                                                             |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Preview     | 1. The author list                                                                                    | 1. Who the authors are and what their backgrounds, motivations, and biases may be                         | 1. Do research about the authors (their affiliations, other research, etc.)                                       |
| First Read  | 1. Abstract<br>2. Skim introduction<br>3. Skim conclusion<br>4. Section headings<br>5. Tables/figures | 1. The framework<br>2. The purpose<br>3. The main arguments<br>4. How the article fits into your research | 1. Highlight unfamiliar words<br>2. Summarize the article in 1 or 2 sentences<br>3. Write down questions you have |
| Second Read | 1. Skim entire article, giving extra time to the beginning and end of each section                    | 1. Look for answers to questions you wrote down                                                           | 1. Search highlighted words you still don't understand                                                            |
| Third Read  | 1. First sentence of every paragraph                                                                  | 1. Arguments<br>2. Evidence<br>3. Conclusions                                                             | 1. Take notes as you read<br>2. Think critically about the article and critique it                                |

### **3. A Faster Approach: “Predatory” Reading**

1. Identify the author’s argument and then assess how each section fits into that argument by reading the topic sentence(s).
2. Look at the transitions to see if they quickly can connect different ideas in the article for you
3. Pay attention when the author references other works because they are important to understanding the argument.
4. Read several times quickly, rather than once in-depth.

## 4. Gleaning Writing Tips from Other Articles

1. Reading academic writing will undoubtedly help your own writing.
2. If you read a journal article that you enjoy or find easy to follow, investigate why. Maybe the author(s) clearly lay out their structure in the introduction, and use excellent section transitions to assist the flow and cohesiveness of the article. Conversely, if you read an article you particularly dislike, also investigate why. Take notes as to what you like and dislike so that you can transfer those lessons to your writing.
3. Pay attention to the structure of the article—How long is introduction? How does the author use transitions?
4. In what voice is the article written? Reading other articles in your field and that are published in your target journal will indicate what voice the journal expects and/permits.
5. Are there visuals? Are they pleasing and effective? Why or why not?
6. How did the author present the conclusions? Most people like crisp recommendations—the “so what?”
7. Study the abstract to determine if it accurately conveys what the article is about. Whether you think it does or does not convey the article well, take note of the elements that are useful or are missing. This will help you write a strong abstract.

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### Sources and Additional Resources:

- 1 Penn State: Critically Reading Journal Articles
- 2 Carlburg, J. & Zasowski, G. How to read a journal article
- 3 University of British Columbia: Predatory Reading
- 4 University of New England: Reading and Taking Notes on Scholarly Journal Articles
- 5 Rice University: How to read a Scientific Article
- 6 Duke University: How to Read and Review a Scientific Journal Article

## 7 Harvard University: Reading Academic Articles

Graham, A. A guide to reading and analyzing academic articles. Yukon College

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